
The Somerville Fermentation Festival Community Cookbook

Our Awesome Community

2026

Contents

Foreword	1
Appetizers	2
Salt-Brined Pickles	2
Main Courses	4
Breads	5
Yeast Water	5
Country Loaf (Yeast Water)	7

Foreword

This cookbook exists because our community shows up for each other — swapping starters, trading tips, and sharing whatever came out of the oven that week.

Every recipe in these pages was contributed by someone in our group, tested in a real kitchen, and passed along in the spirit of the Somerville Fermentation Festival. We hope you find something here worth making again and again.

Appetizers

Small bites to open the table - shareable, forgiving, and forgiving of last-minute substitutions.

Salt-Brined Pickles

Prep Time: 30 mins | **Fermentation Time:** 5 days (or more) | **Servings:** 1 quart
Contributor: Flora

Description

A brief, 1-2 sentence story or description of the dish. Why is it special?

Equipment

- ☐ 1 **quart-sized (32 oz) glass jar**
- ☐ 1 **Nonmetal lid** (optional)
- ☐ 1 **Fermentation weight** (optional)
- ☐ 1 **Scale** (optional)

Ingredients

- ☐ 1 lb **fresh, firm vegetables** - Ex: carrots, celery, cauliflower, pickling cucumbers, string beans, radish, etc.
- ☐ 1 tbsp **additive-free salt** - Sea salt or Himalayan salt are recommended; avoid using salts with iodine or anti-caking agents.
- ☐ **Herbs and spices (optional)** - Common pickling spices include dill, mustard seed, black peppercorn, coriander, horseradish, bay leaf, garlic, and hot pepper flakes.
- ☐ **Tannin source (optional)** - Tannins help keep your veggies crunchy. Sources of tannins include bay leaf, grape leaf, horseradish leaf, or a black teabag.

Instructions

1. **Rinse your vegetables:** Under cold, running water, remove any dirt. If using cucumbers, remove the blossom end (1/8 inch) and optionally soak in cold water for 30-60 minutes.
2. **Pack your jar:** Loosely pack your jar with vegetables (chopped or whole), including any herbs or spices.

Optional: For crunchier pickles, add a source of tannins such as bay leaf, grape leaf, or a black teabag. This is especially helpful when making cucumber pickles.

1. **Add salt:** Add approx. 1 tbsp salt (this will equate to about 2% salt by mass if using a scale). Fill the jar to the top with water, cover with a lid, and invert the jar several times to dissolve the salt.

Note: Salt helps protect vegetables from spoilage. You may adjust the quantity of salt to taste, but do not go below 1% salt by mass (approx. 1.5 tsp per quart jar).

1. **Ferment:** Allow to ferment at **room temperature**, out of direct sunlight. After about 24 hours they will begin to produce carbon dioxide and may leak water out of the jar. 1. **Taste:** Start tasting your pickles after about 5 days. Once they taste sour enough for you, move them to the refrigerator to slow down the fermentation process. Consume within 3-6 months for best flavor.

Note: Keep veggies submerged below the brine to prevent contamination by airborne molds and yeasts. If a white film develops on the liquid's surface, it is a form of yeast called Kahm. This is harmless but can contribute to softening and the development of off flavors.

Chef's Tip:

Email Flora at somfermfest@gmail.com with any questions or visit www.somervillefermfest.com for info on upcoming fermentation events!

Main Courses

Breads

Sourdough, patience, and a little bit of flour on everything you own.

Yeast Water

Prep Time: 3 mins | **Fermentation Time:** 5-7 days | **Servings:** About 225g yeast water **Contributor:** Patrick

Description

This recipe ferments raisins in water. The end result is water full of natural yeast that can leaven a loaf of bread. **Note:** Bread baked with yeast water will not taste like raisins.

Equipment

- ☐ 1 **Large jar** (needs to hold around 14oz of liquid)
- ☐ 1 **Kitchen scale**

Ingredients

- ☐ 300g **Filtered water** (use room temperature water)
- ☐ 100g **Organic raisins**

Instructions

1. **Combine raisins and water:** Place the water and raisins into a large, clean jar. Cover with a lid.
2. **Stir:** After 24 hours, stir the raisins and water. If you are using an airtight container, you can shake the jar of water instead of stirring.
3. **Ferment yeast water:** Stir the water every day for at least five days.

4. **Strain:** When all of the raisins are floating, the water is bubbly, and agitating the water makes bubbles, the fermentation is done. Strain the raisins from the yeast water. Store the water in a clean container, and place it in the fridge. The yeast water can last about two weeks in the fridge.

 Chef's Tip:

- The country loaf bread recipe (see next page) requires 200g of yeast water. The yeast water recipe should have a little bit left over. Use the extra yeast water to seed the next batch. This will help speed up fermentation times.
- Yeast water does not contain the same lactic acid bacteria found in a traditional sourdough starter. Bread made with yeast water will not have the same flavor as sourdough, but it still makes an excellent loaf of bread.
- Fermentation depends on the ambient temperature. During the summer, perhaps it takes only 4 days to ferment a batch of yeast water. In the winter, it could take over a week.
- Unhealthy things can grow on the exposed raisins floating in water. That is why it is important to stir the water each day. Discard the water if you see things growing or floating. Sediment at the bottom of jar is okay.
- Almost any fruit can be used to make yeast water (fresh apples are common). Do try to use organic fruit. However, avoid acidic fruit like kiwis and pineapple.

Country Loaf (Yeast Water)

Prep Time: 3 days | **Cook Time:** 40 mins | **Servings:** 1 loaf **Contributor:** Patrick

Description

This recipe makes a rustic loaf of country bread using yeast water as the leavening agent. This recipe assumes you have fermented yeast water. Please see the Yeast Water recipe (previous page). Remember, dough is a living thing that responds to its local environment. You may need to make changes depending on the temperature.

Equipment

- ☐ 1 **large bowl**
- ☐ 1 **Bowl scraper**
- ☐ 1 **Proofing basket** (a kitchen bowl lined with a tea towel works as well)
- ☐ 1 **Cast iron pot with lid** (enamel coated works as well)
- ☐ 1 **Scale**

Ingredients

- ☐ 400 grams **bread flour**
- ☐ 100 grams **whole wheat flour**
- ☐ 150 grams **filtered water**
- ☐ 200 grams **yeast water**
- ☐ 12 grams **sea salt**

Instructions

Day 1

1. **Prepare the poolish:** In a container, pour 200 grams of your yeast water, and 200 grams of flour. Use all (100g) of the whole wheat flour, as well as 100g of the bread flour.

2. **Mix well:** Mix the above ingredients together well, so that everything is well incorporated. There should be no dry spots of flour.
3. **Let ferment:** Loosely cover the jar, and let sit at room temperature (72 to 75 Fahrenheit) for 10 hours.

Day 2

1. **Hydrate the poolish:** In a large bowl, mix together the 150g of filtered water and the poolish. Try to dissolve any large clumps of poolish in the water. The water should become frothy.
2. **Mix the dough:** Add the remaining 300g of bread flour to the bowl, and mix thoroughly. Keep mixing until no more flour is visible. Be sure to scrape down the sides of the bowl as you go.
3. **Let rest:** Cover the bowl with a plate (or other lid), and let the flour hydrate for 30 minutes.
4. **Add the salt:** Sprinkle the salt over the dough. With a *wet* hand, squeeze and fold the dough so that the salt is evenly distributed and no longer visible.
5. **Let rest:** Cover the dough, and let it rest for 30 minutes.
6. **Stretch and fold 1:** Perform the first set of stretch and folds. With a *wet* hand, grab a portion of the dough. Pull it up and stretch the dough (do not stretch the dough so much that it starts to tear). Fold the handful of dough back into the center of the dough ball. Grab another corner of the dough and do the same thing. Work your way around the dough ball. You should stretch and fold the dough about four times.
7. **Let rest:** Cover the dough, and let it rest for 30 minutes.
8. **Stretch and fold 2:** Perform the second set of stretch and folds. With a *wet* hand, grab a portion of the dough. Pull it up and stretch the dough (do not stretch the dough so much that it starts to tear). Fold the handful of dough back into the center of the dough ball. Grab another corner of the dough and do the same thing. Work your way around the dough ball. You should stretch and fold the dough about four times.
9. **Let rest:** Cover the dough, and let it rest for 30 minutes.
10. **Stretch and fold 3:** Perform the third and final set of stretch and folds. With a *wet* hand, grab a portion of the dough. Pull it up and stretch the dough (do not stretch the dough so much that it starts to tear). Fold the handful of dough back into the center of the dough ball. Grab another corner of the dough and do the same thing. Work your way around the dough ball. You should stretch and fold the dough about four times.

11. **Bulk ferment:** Cover the bowl and let the dough rest on the counter. Depending on the temperature of your room (and the temperature of the dough), the dough should rest for 1.5 to 2 hours. On a hot or warm day, it may take less time. During the winter, you may need to rest the dough for longer.
12. **Preshaping:** When the dough is soft, pillowy, and risen 20% to 30%, it is time to preshape the dough. Turn the dough out onto a floured work surface. Gently work the dough into a taught ball. Cover with the bowl (or towel) and let rest 20 minutes.
13. **Shaping:** Uncover the dough, and flour the surface. Flip the dough over. Grab a small portion of the edge of the dough and pull it towards the middle. Slightly press down. Do this with each corner of the dough until it is roughly circular in shape. Roll the dough over so the folded side is touching the counter. With your hands, drag and seal the dough into a taught ball.
14. **Cold proof:** Flour a proofing basket or a towel-lined bowl. Place the dough smooth side down in the basket. Cover the basket, and place it in the fridge to rest overnight.

Day 3

1. **Preheat the oven:** Place a cast iron pot (with lid) in the oven, and set it to 500F. Let the oven preheat for an hour.
2. **Scoring:** Take the dough out of the oven, and turn it out on to a sheet of parchment paper. Using a razor blade, slash the dough at a 45-degree angle from one end to the other. Take the cast iron pot out of the oven, and lower the dough into the pot with the parchment paper. Cover the cast iron pot with the lid.
3. **Bake:** Turn the oven down to 450F. Place the pot into the oven. Bake for 20 minutes. Remove the lid, and bake uncovered for another 20 minutes. When the loaf is a dark, golden brown, remove it from the oven.
4. **Cool:** Let the loaf rest for two hours on a cooling rack before slicing.

Chef's Tip:

- In terms of baker's percentages, this recipe uses 20% whole wheat, 70% hydration, and 2.5% salt.
- Timing is everything in bread making. On a warm day, use cooler water. On a cold day, use warmer water. You may need to adjust the bulk fermentation based on the ambient temperature.

- Don't be afraid to vary the kinds and amounts of flour you use. Ancient grains like spelt, Khorasan (also called kamut), and einkorn are all delicious. If you can find an artisianal mill, see if they have any bolted wheat. Do keep in mind that whole wheat flour absorbs more water, so feel free to up the hydration to 75% (or more).